A Working Girl Can't Win

By Deborah Garrison

INTRODUCTION

These are the twentysomethings, who live in the post-hippie '80s and '90s and feel that the movements of the '60s did not change the world. The legacy to the twentysomethings is a bleak future in which they can never hope to be as successful as their parents. Disenchanted with treading the career path and pursuing "pointless jobs done grudgingly to little applause," life is a series of vignettes, of incidents wherein one tries desperately to derive some deeper meaning. Selections from A Working Girl Can't Win by Deborah Garrison.

Worked Late on a Tuesday Night

Again.
Midtown is blasted out and silent,
drained of the crowd and its doggy day.
I trample the scraps of deli lunches
some ate outdoors as they stared dumbly
or hooted at us career girls-the haggard
beauties, the vivid can-dos, open raincoats aflap

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in the March wind as we crossed to and fro
in front of the Public Library
Never thought you'd be one of them,
did you, little lady?
Little Miss Phi Beta Kappa,
with your closetful of pleated
skirts, twenty-nine till death do us
part! Don't you see?
The good schoolgirl turns thirty,
forty, singing the song of time management
all day long, lugging the briefcase
home. So at 10:00 PM
you're standing here
with your hand in the air,
cold but too stubborn to reach
into your pocket for a glove, cursing
the freezing rain as though it were
your difficulty. It's pathetic,
and nobody's fault but
your own. Now

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the tears,
down into the collar.
Cabs, cabs, but none for hire.
I haven't had dinner; I'm not half
of what I meant to be.
Among other things, the mother
of three. Too tired, tonight,
to seduce the father.

TRANSITION

Young adults feel that they have to do fantastic things by their mid-20s, like they see in the media. Twentysomethings are depressed because they believe they've been "sold" on a lifestyle — the 20s aren't as easy as their idle thoughts.

An Idle Thought

I'm never going to sleep
with Martin Amis
or anyone famous.
At twenty-one I scotched
my chance to be
one of the seductresses
of the century,
a vamp on the rise through the ranks
of literary Gods and military men,
who wouldn't stop at the President:
she'd take the Pentagon by storm
in halter dress and rhinestone extras,
letting fly the breasts that shatter
crystal--then dump him, too,
and break his power-broker heart.
Such women are a breed apart.
I'm the type
who likes to cook--no,
really likes it; does the bills;
buys towels and ties;
closes her eyes during kisses:
a true first wife.
The seductress when she's fifty
nobody misses, but a first wife
always knows she's first,
and the second (if he leaves me
when he's forty-five) won't forget me

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either. The mention of my name,
the sight of our son--his and mine--
will make her tense; despite
perfected bod, highlighted hair
and hip career, she'll always fear
that way back there
he loved me more
and better simply
for being first.
But ho:
the fantasy's unfair to him,
who picked me young and never tried
another. The only woman he's ever left
was his mother.

TRANSITION

For many American women, rushing from work to home to school—then getting up and doing it all over again—has become the norm. Juggling a spouse, children, boss and friends all adds up to a hectic lifestyle that can put your physical and mental health in the dumps. It's easy to conclude that A Working Girl Can't Win.

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A Working Girl Can't Win

Is this the birth of a pundit
or a slut? Is she the woman
they courted for her youthful edge
or a kiss-and-tell bimbo,
a careerist coquette?
The loyal daughter to spin doctors
losing their hair or soul sister
to feminist essayists everywhere?
Is her meteoric rise the source
of her potential demise?
Is her worldview equal parts
yuppie whine and new-age rumor?
Can we get a biopsy on her latest
breast tumor? Is she a failed
anorexic, or a diet-pill faddist
who'll let it all go and get fat
in her fifties? Are her roots
rural, right-leaning? Is she Jewish,
self-hating? Past her sell-by date,

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or still ovulating?
Will her husband talk?
Does he mind her success?
Does anyone know -- does he see
her undressed? Has she been
photographed? Will she play
truth or dare? And more to the point,
does anyone care?
Come next year, will the masses
be reading her story? Will she be
on the cover, or well past her glory?
Either way, we'll move on, and she'll tire
before long: only her children will grieve
at the way she was wronged.

TRANSITION

But maybe failing isn't so bad. In fact, it may be the only rescue these twentysomething superwomen can hope for. It's not like you can just walk into your bosses office and say "Please, fire me."

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Please Fire Me

Here comes another alpha male,
and all the other alphas
are snorting and pawing,
kicking up puffs of acrid dust

while the silly little hens
clatter back and forth
on quivering claws and raise
a titter about the fuss.

Here comes another alpha male--
a man's man, a dealmaker,
holds tanks of liquor,
charms them pantsless at lunch:

I've never been sicker.
Do I have to stare into his eyes
and sympathize? If I want my job
I do. Well I think I'm through

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with the working world,

through with warming eggs

and being Zenlike in my detachment

from all things Ego.

I'd like to go

somewhere else entirely,

and I don't mean

Europe.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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